ChatGPT Quick Start Guide.

START HERE: PROJECTS, MODELS AND EFFORT

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Put each ongoing job in a Project

A Project is a folder for chats, files and instructions about one job. Every new chat in it starts with that context, so you stop re-explaining.

Stop repeating yourself Write project instructions once, such as audience, tone and format. Every chat in the project follows them.	**Keep files in reach** Upload the syllabus, policy or template once. ChatGPT draws on it in every project chat.	**Keep work separate** Project-only memory keeps a project's chats apart from your other conversations. Shared projects always use it.

01 Pick one recurring job, such as a course, committee or weekly report.

02 Create a project and name it after that job.

03 Add two or three reference files and a few lines of instructions.

04 Move related chats into the project. They pick up its instructions and files.

■ Share a project with Edit or Chat access when a colleague needs the same context. Use approved, de-identified files and follow your student-data policy.

PICK A MODEL AND EFFORT

Match the model to the work. Start at low effort.

Narrow and repeated Try GPT-6 Luna at Low for sorting, extraction or a task with a clear right answer.	**Judgment across sources** Use GPT-6.1 Sol at Low or Medium for reports, reconciling documents and multistep work. Use the lowest effort that passes your check.	**Consequential decisions** Increase effort when needed and add human review. Keep scope explicit. Consult your campus policy and the current Model Value Map.

■ Raise effort only after a result fails your check. Higher effort takes more time and usage. Menu labels and models vary by account and campus settings.

CHAT, WORK OR CODEX?

Choose the surface for the result

Chat Questions, quick drafts and explanations.	**Work** Multistep jobs that produce a finished artifact.	**Codex** Code, tests and repositories.

■ Quick win: connect an approved document service, find five recent documents and ask for a one-line summary of each.

SCHEDULED TASKS

Let ChatGPT show up on a schedule

Monday Open items and deadlines.	**Wednesday** Find stale documents in an approved shared folder.	**Friday** Draft a weekly update for review.

01 Open Scheduled when available, or describe the task and when it should run.

02 Choose a one-time or recurring schedule. Supported connected apps may offer event triggers.

03 Review the account, sources, instructions and permissions before relying on a run.

04 Check results and paused tasks in Scheduled. Codex automations are managed separately.

- Computer-bound tasks need that device available. Cloud tasks have different requirements. If a task's model retires, update it before the next run.

FIND USEFUL TOOLS

Start with the work you already do

Documents and email Google Drive, Gmail or Outlook: find an approved document, summarize a thread or draft a reply.	**Research and study** Consensus or Quizlet, where available: explore research or build practice flashcards. Check sources and accuracy.	**Design** Canva, where available: turn an outline into an event flyer. Review the result before sharing.

- Also check Calendar, SharePoint, Slack, Teams and Notion. Availability varies. Use approved campus services and de-identified examples; follow your student-data policy.

MAKE, BUILD OR BORROW

Turn a task you repeat into a skill

Make a skill You repeat a focused task, such as a weekly update or a document review.	**Make a plugin** A workflow needs connected services or a bundle your team can reuse.	**Install one** Search the Plugins directory before building a tool that already exists.

01 Name one repeated task and its required result.

02 Use Skill Creator where available. Describe the goal, steps and output format.

03 Test with de-identified examples and refine the instructions.

04 Share where your workspace permits. Name a maintainer and provide example prompts.

- Good first skills: meeting notes to action items, policy-template checks or clearer help articles.

HABITS FROM A WORKING SETUP

Six habits that make AI more useful

- Name the task, the tools and the result you want.
- Ask ChatGPT to challenge your request if it is unclear.
- Keep a short handoff in each project: done, next and open questions.
- Verify facts and saves before you rely on them.
- Search for an existing tool before you build one.
- Add one new habit at a time.

KNOW THE DIFFERENCE

A skill handles a task. A plugin bundles a workflow.

	Custom GPT	Skill	Plugin
Purpose	A separate chatbot	Reusable task instructions	Skills, files and connected capabilities
Tools	Apps or custom actions	Uses tools available to the task	May include connected apps
Sharing	Existing GPT permissions	Account and workspace controls	Share intentionally; apps authorize separately

INSTALL AND SHARE

Test privately. Share on purpose.

01 Open Plugins or the app directory shown in your account. Review the tool and its capabilities.

02 Select Install plugin when shown, then connect required apps using the intended account.

03 Start a chat and mention the installed tool where supported.

04 For your own plugin, test first, add example prompts and name a maintainer. Review sharing permissions; workspace publication is a separate permission.

■ Installing a plugin does not grant access to files or bypass your provider's permissions. Recipients may need to install it and connect their own apps.

IF YOU BUILT CUSTOM GPTS

Move your GPTs to plugins before they retire

Custom GPT retirement is scheduled for December 11, 2026. Some Enterprise workspaces have an approved February 11, 2027 deferral. Follow your account or campus notice.

What moves	What needs attention	Your move
Published GPT instructions become a skill. Reference files and supported connected apps can move with the plugin.	Custom actions and sharing settings need review or rebuilding. Existing conversations remain accessible.	When available, open My GPTs > Migrate to plugin. Test familiar requests in the same workspace before switching.

■ For affected Enterprise workspaces, October 26 is the planned end of new GPT creation. Dates and access depend on workspace notices.

CHECKLIST

Try these next

[ ] Create a project with instructions and one file	[ ] Find the model and effort controls
[ ] Set one scheduled task and check its result	[ ] Connect one approved app and summarize a document
[ ] Create one focused skill with Skill Creator	[ ] Run one multistep task in Work
[ ] Ask your campus admin what tools and data are allowed	[ ] If you own custom GPTs, plan and test their replacement

Sources: Projects in ChatGPT · GPT retirement and migration · Plugins and connected apps · Skills in ChatGPT · Scheduled tasks · Model specifications and API prices · October Chat model release · Current model guidance